

« BEFORE

The Japanese occupation of Indochina in World War II effectively ended French rule.

CHANGING STATUS

In March 1945, Japanese troops occupying Indochina declared **Vietnam, Laos, and Cambodia independent**. Despite this, Indochina remained under Japanese control. Then, in August 1945, **Japan was defeated by the Allies**, including the United States, Britain, China, and France.



JAPAN SIGNS THE INSTRUMENT OF SURRENDER, 1945

By the time Japanese forces occupied Vietnam in March 1945, the Viet Minh movement was already solidly embedded in the Vietnamese population, with a network of cells in towns and villages. No longer threatened by the French colonial army, the Viet Minh's guerrilla force had increased its strength in the Viet Bac region north of Hanoi, aided by agents of the American OSS (Office of Strategic Services), the forerunner of the CIA, who had seen the Viet Minh as a useful ally in America's war against Japan. But Viet Minh commander Vo Nguyen Giap mostly avoided fighting the Japanese occupiers, keeping his limited forces intact for a future bid for power.

Japan's surrender to the Allies after the dropping of atom bombs on Hiroshima and Nagasaki had left Vietnam without any effective authority in place. The Viet Minh took advantage of this power vacuum, raising its flag from one end of the country to the other in a general insurrection. The Viet Minh leadership established itself in Hanoi.